

7, Who Could Emerge Victorious from The Great Expansion?

There were not a few ethnic groups participating in the historical event of **The Great Expansion** (大扩张). Even for ethnic groups speaking Indo-European languages and entering the same massive region, they did not necessarily identify with one another. In China, even if **The Great Expansion** initially did not escape the control of the Zhou royal court, starting from the Eastern Zhou Dynasty, the various vassal states were forced to fight their own battles. In the historical process, although the emergence of a certain trend or mutation possesses inevitability, the groups or individuals endowed with the conditions to realize it are not necessarily singular. As for who precisely can claim the paramount merit, that is a moment that severely tests the subjective initiative and comprehensive capabilities of heroic figures; however, luck and timing are also indispensable. Today, the **founding heartlands** (龙兴之地) of the first batch of empires that arose after **The Great Expansion** we observe were universally situated on the periphery of civilization.

The Qin people, who unified China, had already established themselves in the western frontier of China during the Western Zhou period (*this is coincidentally a pun here, referring both to the specific place of Xi Qianqiu and the western border of the Zhu Xia [诸夏] at that time*). They later completely occupied the former lands of the Zhou people, then expanded southward to annex the Hanzhong and Ba-Shu regions, and ultimately conquered the other vassal states to the east. The state of Magadha, which unified India, was situated remarkably far east among the Indian Mahajanapadas; considering that the Aryans entered India from the northwest, this was precisely the eastern frontier of the Indo-Aryan states. In the mid-6th century BC, Magadha annexed the even more easterly state of Anga. At this point, the Magadhans had evidently secured a geopolitically superior position comparable to that of the Qin people. Over the course of the subsequent dynasties, they continuously expanded, ultimately ballooning into a massive empire during the Maurya Dynasty. Persia and Media need no further elaboration; these two regimes were situated on the periphery of the **Near East** (近东) civilization in the traditional sense (*up until 600 BC*). Macedonia was located on the northern periphery among the various Greek city-states, and was even deemed excessively barbaric by some southern Greek city-states. The waters faced by the city of Rome were the Western Mediterranean. Let alone comparing it to the traditional city-states of the Eastern Mediterranean, even compared to relatively remote colonial city-states like Carthage and Syracuse, Rome deviated even further from the civilizational center of the Eastern Mediterranean.

This consistency, in a certain sense, obliquely reflects the characteristics of the era of **The Great Expansion**: being too close to the center of struggle merely wastes strength in vain with meager returns, entangling one in useless diplomatic relations and preventing the adoption of flexible stances. The peripheral regions, conversely, are not only exempt from these anxieties and perils, but they can also, while avoiding excessive attention, annex the more backward small states and tribes deemed as **barbarians** (蛮族) (*which in a certain sense is a continuation of The Great Expansion*), thereby expanding their own territories, increasing their populations, and ultimately securing an absolute advantage in national power. We might as well imagine: if situated in an era that was not expanding, but rather one where civilizational borders remained chronically fixed, could wars of unification still possibly conclude in the pattern established by the first batch of **classical empires** (古典帝国)? I am afraid this would be impossible. Under such conditions, even if the victor does not necessarily originate from the civilizational core region, they at least cannot be situated too far from the core. The core region of a civilization implies advanced socio-economic development, the most

prosperous commercial activities, commanding pivotal communication arteries, and furthermore, representing righteousness and orthodoxy; it is a battleground of paramount strategic importance. Therefore, in ancient China there was the saying of **competing for the Zhongyuan (中原)** (逐鹿中原). This was even more typical in a closed island nation like Japan: samurai daimyo located too far from the Kinki region obviously stood no chance of sitting upon the throne of the Tenkabito [天下人], and both the Oda and Toyotomi regimes similarly completed the unification of Japan by establishing their foothold within the Kinai.

Therefore, I believe the actions of the Holy Roman Kaiser during the **High Middle Ages** (中世纪盛期) were utterly unwise. In this era of land reclamation and explosive population growth (*relative to an agricultural society, of course; it cannot be compared to post-Industrial Revolution*), the German Kaiser failed to focus their gaze eastward; conversely, they marched to Italy time and time again, squandering time, manpower, and wealth, only to ultimately end up with nothing. History demonstrates that even if the Holy Roman Kaiser had remained completely inactive, the autonomous actions of the minor border vassals and knightly orders in eastern Germany alone had already secured colossal territories for the Germans by the **early modern period** (近代) (Ostsiedlung). The two most vital nations later on, Prussia and Austria, both benefited tremendously from this eastward expansion (*Prussia, in particular, was built entirely upon the foundation of eastward expansion*). Today, it is already utterly impossible to imagine how colossal an achievement the Germans could have secured in Europe, and how the French could have possibly responded, if the Holy Roman Kaiser of that era had been slightly more rational and balanced their energies invested in Italian and Eastern affairs. But I digress.

7，谁能在大扩张运动中脱颖而出

参与大扩张这一历史事件的族群并不少，即使是同样操着印欧语进入同一个大区域的族群，他们也未必相互认同。在中国，即使大扩张在最初没有脱离周王室的掌控，但是从东周开始各个诸侯国也不得不各自为战。在历史进程中，虽然某个趋势或者变化的产生具有必然性，但是有条件去实现这一点的团体或者个人未必只有一个，究竟谁能立下首功那就是十分考验英雄人物们主观能动性和综合能力的时刻了，不过时运也是缺不了的。今天我们看到的大扩张之后兴起的第一批帝国，其龙兴之地无不在文明的边陲。统一中国的秦人在西周时期便立于中国的西垂（这里恰好是双关语，既指西犬丘这个地方，又指当时诸夏的西部边境），后来全据周人故地，又向南兼并汉中及巴蜀地区，最终向东征服了其他诸侯国。统一印度的摩羯陀国（Magadha）在印度列国中非常靠东，考虑到雅利安人是从西北方向进入的印度，这里恰好是印度雅利安国家的东部边境。摩羯陀国在公元前六世纪中叶便吞并了更东方的鸯伽国（Anga），至此摩羯陀人显然取得了与秦人相当的优越地缘位置，再接下来几个王朝统治下不断扩张，最终在孔雀王朝时期膨胀成为一个大帝国。波斯和米底自不必说，这两个政权处于近东文明传统意义上（到公元前600年为止）的边缘。马其顿在各个希腊城邦中处于北部边缘，甚至被南部的一些希腊城邦认为太过野蛮。罗马城所面向的水域是西地中海，这不要说跟东地中海的传统城邦相比，就是与迦太基、叙拉古这样比较偏远的殖民城邦来说都还更偏离东地中海的文明中心。

这种一致性某种意义上也从侧面反映了大扩张时代的特征，太过靠近斗争中心只会平白损失力量而少有收益，牵扯无用的外交关系而无法采取灵活的立场，而边陲地区不但免于这些忧患和危险，还可以在避免遭到过多关注的情况下吞并更加落后的，被视为蛮夷的小国家和部落（某种意义上说是大扩张的一种继续），使得自身的领土扩大，人口增加最终令国力获得优势。我们不妨想象一下，如果在一个不是扩张的，反倒是文明边境长期固定的年代，统一战争还可能以第一批古典帝国建立的那种模式结束吗？这

恐怕就不能了，在这种条件下，胜利者不说一定来源于文明核心地区，至少也不能离核心太远。文明的核心地区意味着社会经济发达，商业活动最繁荣，扼守交通要冲，并且还代表着大义名分和正统性，是兵家必争之地。因此中国古有逐鹿中原之说，在日本这样封闭的岛国就更典型，太远离近畿地区的武士大名显然没有机会坐上“天下人”的宝座，织田政权和丰臣政权也是立足畿内完成了日本的统一。

因此我认为神圣罗马帝国皇帝在中世纪盛期的行动实在不明智，在这个土地开发和人口激增的年代（当然是相对农业社会来说，不可能跟工业革命之后比），德国皇帝不把目光聚焦于东方，反倒一次又一次跑到意大利去，耗时耗力耗财不说，最后也落得一场空。历史表明，哪怕神圣罗马帝国皇帝无所作为，单单是德国东部的边境小诸侯和骑士团的自主行动，到近代的时候就已经为德国人取得了庞大的领土（*Ostsiedlung*），后来最重要的两个国家普鲁士和奥地利都受益于东扩（尤其是普鲁士就建立在东扩的基础上）。现在已经完全难以想象如果当年的神圣罗马帝国皇帝能够稍微理智一些，平衡在意大利事务和东方事务上投入的精力，德国人在欧洲究竟能取得多大的成就，法国人又能怎么应对呢。话扯远了。